SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

STRENGTHENING THE FRONTLINE OF THE PHILIPPINE ARMY: EXPLORING THE REAL-LIFE SITUATON OF CAFGU

A Thesis Presented To
The Faculty of
College of Criminal Justice Education

In Partial Requirements for the Degree
BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN CRIMINOLOGY

By

JULIAN MAE R. MANSUETO
AIMIE S. MACASLING
AIROD G. DORIA
KEN ADRIAN TEMPORADA
BREINT A. TULOP
XYREL TAGAPULOT

ADVISER: MR. JEFFREY B. YOSA, MSCJ (C)

May 2026

SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

TABLE OF CONTENTS

			Pages
	TITLE PAGE		i
	CERTIFICATE OF PANEL APPROVAL		
	ABSTRACT		
	DEDICATION		
	ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS		
	TABLE OF CONTENTS		ii
	LIST OF TABLES		
	LIST OF FIGURES		
	CHAPTER		
	1	**THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE**	1
		1.1 Background of the study	1
		1.2 Review of Related Literature	3
		1.3 Theoretical Framework	7
		1.4 Conceptual Framework	9
		1.5 Statement of the problem/ Objective of the study	9
		1.6 Scope and Limitation	10
		1.7 Definition of Terms	11
	2	**RESEARCH METHODOLOGY**	12
		2.1 Research Design	12
		2.2 Research Environment Population and Sample	13
		2.3 Research Date and Analysis Plan	14
		2.4 Research Ethical Standards	15
	REFERENCES		20S

CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

The Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) serves as one of the vital auxiliary forces of the Philippine Army, functioning as the frontline of defense in local communities, particularly in conflict-prone and geographically isolated areas. Since its establishment under Executive Order No. 264 in 1987, the CAFGU has played a crucial role in supporting the military's counterinsurgency and peacekeeping operations (Department of National Defense [DND], 2018). Their presence has strengthened the connection between the military and civilians, maintaining peace and order while contributing to national security. However, despite their significant role, the real-life situations, struggles, and welfare of CAFGU members remain underexplored and often overshadowed by mainstream military narratives.

The CAFGU's operational effectiveness is often challenged by issues such as low compensation, lack of benefits, insufficient training, and exposure to high-risk duties. These challenges have direct implications on their performance, motivation, and well-being. Over time, the CAFGU program has evolved through various reforms by the Department of National Defense and the Armed Forces of the Philippines to improve professionalism and accountability among members (AFP, 2022). Yet, the continuing socioeconomic struggles faced by CAFGU members stemming from poverty and limited livelihood opportunities remain pressing concerns (Eastin & Zech, 2022).

Globally, community-based defense systems and auxiliary forces are recognized as vital partners of national armies, especially in countries facing internal security threats

(Ismael, 2023). Similar formations exist in nations such as Indonesia, Thailand, and Nigeria, where local militias or reserve units complement regular forces in safeguarding rural and conflict-affected communities.

Auxiliary forces help extend military reach and enhance civilian cooperation in counterinsurgency efforts. However, scholars also warn of issues such as limited training, lack of welfare support, and human rights concerns (Bhatia, 2021). In the Philippines, CAFGU focuses on their historical creation, military functions, and legal framework, but lacks in-depth exploration of their lived experiences, motivations, and social conditions.

This study will be conducted to explore and analyze the real-life situations of CAFGU members in the Philippines, emphasizing their roles, challenges, and contributions to the Philippine Army's frontline operations. It seeks to uncover the underlying socioeconomic and motivational factors that influence their service, the challenges and risks they face in the field, and how these experiences shape community security and development. The research aims to provide insights that will assist policymakers and military leaders in formulating more responsive programs and welfare mechanisms for CAFGU personnel (AFP, 2022).

This study is significant because it provides an in-depth understanding of the realities faced by CAFGU members, who serve as unsung heroes in maintaining local peace and stability. By shedding light on their socioeconomic conditions, motivations, and operational challenges, the findings will benefit multiple stakeholders particularly the Armed Forces of the Philippines, local government units, and policymakers by informing strategies for better training, welfare programs, and community integration. Furthermore, it will serve as a valuable reference for future researchers in the fields of defense studies, sociology, and public policy, contributing to a more comprehensive

understanding of grassroots security systems in the Philippines.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

Socio-Economic Factors

Socioeconomic factors such as poverty and the lack of job opportunities greatly influence individuals' decisions to join the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU). In many rural communities, limited sources of income and unstable livelihoods push people to seek alternative means of support. As a result, joining the CAFGU becomes not only a form of public service but also a practical response to economic hardship and the need for financial stability.

Poverty and Lack of Job Opportunities

In Nigeria, personal motivations and incentive factors as main drivers of the participation of people in the militia movement in Yobe state. People are attracted to paramilitary force because of material gains. Therefore, the biggest attraction of the participants to the paramilitary exercise is the expectation of a steady paycheck. Participants indicated that becoming a militia enhances the ability to eke out stipends from both government institutions, and other humanitarian bodies. Gana (2021)

Over 60% of young people in Africa are unemployed, creating a serious youth unemployment issue that exacerbates instability and limits peace building chances. Youth unemployment has serious repercussions. Young people are frequently pushed toward destructive coping strategies, such as engaging in violent extremism or criminal activity, by economic hardship and a lack of possibilities. Armed organizations take advantage of these weaknesses by providing jobless adolescents with financial incentives and a feeling of community. For instance, terrorist groups like Boko Haram have enlisted young people in Cameroon and the Sahel by promising them social mobility and economic freedom. These

relationships demonstrate how unemployment both fuels violence and impedes efforts at peace building (Mbukop, 2025).

In the Philippines, one crucial factor influencing the willingness of individuals to join CAFGU is economic in nature. According to a study by Eastin & Zech (2022) poverty and unemployment are significant drivers for enlistment. Many CAFGU members are attracted by the promise of a regular stipends or allowances, which serve as an important livelihood support. However, this reliance on economic incentives also introduces vulnerabilities: low compensation, inconsistent allowances, and lack of alternative economic opportunities can affect morale and retention.

Socioeconomic hardship particularly poverty and limited job opportunities plays a significant role in driving individuals to enlist in CAFGU. One empirical study based on survey and interview data from CAFGU members found that poverty and unemployment were key motivators for joining the auxiliary force, with the provision of a relatively steady income cited as a main attraction (Eastin & Zech, 2022). Similarly, Zech and Eastin (2021) argued that decisions to join CAFGU can be understood in terms of household economic calculus: when regular employment is scarce and subsistence uncertain, the alternative of militia service becomes viable as a way to avoid economic disaster. These findings suggest that rather than purely ideological or security- driven motives, many recruits view CAFGU membership as one of the few available pathways out of economic vulnerability.

In addition to economic drivers, modest financial allowances offered to CAFGU members exacerbate the impetus to join, despite the risks. For example, a report by the International Commission of Jurists (ICJ) noted that CAFGU members receive subsistence allowances of around PHP 4,600 per month (approximately US$96), which, while low in absolute terms, represents a meaningful sum for individuals in deprived communities (ICJ, 2021). Moreover,

poverty and unemployment interact with recruitment practices and structural conditions: in some cases, recruitment is informal and barriers are low, making membership accessible to job- seekers and landless peasants eager for any steady engagement (Zech & Eastin, 2021). Consequently, the intersection of economic need, low opportunity cost, and relatively accessible auxiliary military roles forms a potent combination that drives CAFGU enlistment in marginalized areas of the Philippines.

Social and work-related factors affecting motivation

Socio-economic factors and welfare support heavily influence CAFGU recruitment, retention, and morale. Recent policy updates and budget documents (and news reports) indicate changes in allowances and benefits for AFP personnel and auxiliary forces, while livelihood and skills programs provided by agencies such as TESDA have been offered to CAFGU members and former rebels to improve their economic opportunities outside or alongside their military roles. These developments suggest that strengthening the frontline will require not only better military training but also sustainable welfare, compensation, and livelihood interventions that address the economic drivers of enlistment and attrition (Espiritu, 2024).

Scholars and human-rights organizations have raised critical concerns about accountability, insufficient training in rights and rules of engagement, and the risk of abuses when auxiliary forces operate with limited oversight. Historical and contemporary reports argue that militia or auxiliary arrangements that lack rigorous vetting, human-rights training, and transparent command structures can undermine both legitimacy and effectiveness, and may lead to community distrust. Any program to strengthen CAFGU therefore needs to integrate safeguards—clear oversight, human-rights education, and mechanisms for addressing misconduct—to protect civilians and preserve the force's credibility (Gil, 2016).

Social and work-related factors form a critical dimension in understanding why individuals remain motivated and perform in roles that span civilian and auxiliary-security contexts. According to Tuliao, and Chen (2022) **social relatedness** and **autonomy** significantly enhance work motivation among 32,614 respondents from 25 countries: "autonomy and social relatedness positively impacted work motivation" while competence alone unexpectedly hurt motivation. For individuals in auxiliary or volunteer roles, feeling connected to others (social relatedness) and having some control over their activities (autonomy) may matter more for motivation than simply feeling competent. For members of units such as the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU), this highlights the importance of their integration into community networks, recognition by peers and command structure, and feeling a sense of meaningful participation rather than purely technical competence.

In Malaysia, organizational and work-related factors influence motivation and engagement. Both individual motivation and **perceived organizational support** had a significant positive effect on volunteers' work engagement. Volunteers who felt supported by their organization were more motivated and more engaged, thus suggesting that for auxiliary security forces, factors such as recognition, resource provision, training, supervision, and formal support matter considerably. The nature of their work environment, the level of institutional backing they receive, and the quality of supervision and peer support may shape their motivation and performance. Cheah, Suppiah, and Unnithan (2024)

In the Philippines, CAFGU specifically is limited, analogous work sheds light on motivation in conflict-affected roles. Human rights workers in conflict-afflicted areas in the Philippines and found that their motivation stemmed from intrinsic factors (altruism, sense of cause) and strong **community ties** "they are motivated to match the courage of community members…and are strengthened by the strong and reciprocal bonds that they have with the

communities that they serve" Thus, for CAFGU, social and community- based factors likely influence why members stay committed or perform despite low allowances or high risk. Hernandez et.al., (2020)

1.3 Theoretical Framework

This study focuses on strengthening the frontline of the Philippine Army by exploring the real-life situation of the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU). The theoretical basis of the study is anchored in Social Exchange Theory (George Homans, 1961; Peter Blau, 1964), Structural Functionalism (Émile Durkheim, 1893; Talcott Parsons, 1951), and Conflict Theory (Karl Marx, 19th century). These theories collectively provide a foundation for understanding the motivations, roles, challenges, and broader socio-political implications of CAFGU's presence in local communities.

Social Exchange Theory explains the motivations behind CAFGU members' participation by emphasizing the balance of costs and rewards. Individuals join the CAFGU not only out of a sense of patriotism but also due to socio-economic benefits such as allowances, job security, and community recognition. However, these benefits are weighed against the risks of violence, stigma, and lack of institutional support. Through this lens, CAFGU membership can be seen as a rational choice shaped by the interplay of personal needs and external incentives.

Structural Functionalism situates CAFGU within the broader societal framework as an auxiliary force that supports the Philippine Army in maintaining peace and order. From this perspective, CAFGU fulfills a functional role in stabilizing communities, deterring insurgency, and contributing to national security. Their presence helps address gaps in the formal security apparatus, particularly in remote and conflict-affected areas. In this

way, the CAFGU functions as a subsystem of society that sustains equilibrium and social order by working alongside established state institutions.

Conflict Theory, on the other hand, highlights the socio-political tensions that underlie CAFGU operations. Many members are drawn from marginalized and economically disadvantaged sectors, reflecting structural inequalities in society. While they serve as protectors of community security, they are also exposed to systemic risks, exploitation, and vulnerabilities that reinforce their subordinate position in the social hierarchy. This framework allows the study to critically assess how power relations, resource distribution, and class struggles influence the experiences of CAFGU members and the communities they serve.

Together, these theories provide a multidimensional understanding of CAFGU's role and lived realities. Social Exchange Theory sheds light on individual motivations, Structural Functionalism underscores their contribution to societal stability, and Conflict Theory critiques the inequalities embedded in their service. By integrating these perspectives, the study aims to comprehensively analyze the socio-economic conditions, operational challenges, and community impact of CAFGU, thereby offering insights that can inform more effective policies and strategies for peace and security.

Conceptual Framework

INPUT	PROCESS	OUTPUT
Socioeconomic factors, motivations, challenges, and lived experiences of CAFGU members	Data collection through in-depth interviews; thematic analysis and coding of narratives	Identified themes on CAFGU roles, challenges, motivations, and contributions to frontline operations

1.4 Objectives of the Study

General Objectives

To explore and analyze the real-life situation of the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) in the Philippines, with emphasis on their roles, challenges, and contributions in strengthening the frontline operations of the Philippine Army.

Specific Objectives

1. To identify the socioeconomic factors, such as poverty and lack of job opportunities, that lead individuals to join the CAFGU.
2. To analyze the social and work-related factors that affect the motivation and performance of CAFGU members in their duties.
3. To examine the challenges and risks faced by CAFGU members and their impact on community safety and local development.

Scope and Limitation

This study focuses on exploring and analyzing the real-life situation of the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) members assigned in P-10 Afga, Barangay Lower Olave, Buenavista, Agusan del Norte. It examines their socioeconomic conditions, motivations, operational challenges, and contributions to strengthening the frontline operations of the Philippine Army. The research also covers the contextual factors that shape their daily duties, lived experiences, and roles in community security.

The scope of the study is limited to active CAFGU members currently residing and serving in the research location. Data will be gathered through in-depth interviews conducted within the identified barangay. The study will not include perspectives from CAFGU commanders, military officers, or community residents. It also does not measure operational effectiveness through quantitative means, focusing solely on qualitative narratives.

Additionally, the findings of this research will be limited by participants' willingness to share personal experiences, potential self-reporting bias, and the qualitative design, which cannot generalize results to all CAFGU units in the Philippines. Geographical limitations, time constraints, and situational availability of respondents also affected the breadth of data collected. Despite these limitations, the study provides significant insights into the lived realities of CAFGU personnel and the factors that influence their service.

1.5 Definition of Terms

The following terms and statements were operationally and conceptually defined as follows:

Allowance. Refers to the monthly financial support received by CAFGU members from the government as compensation for their service.

Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP). The main military organization of the Philippines that supervises and directs the operations of CAFGU units.

CAFGU (Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit). A paramilitary force composed of civilian volunteers trained and deployed to assist the AFP in maintaining peace and security in local communities.

Community Security. Refers to the protection and stability provided by CAFGU units within local areas, especially those affected by insurgency.

Counterinsurgency. Military and community-based operations where CAFGU members assist the AFP in addressing and preventing insurgent activities.

Insurgency. Armed rebellion or conflict within the country that CAFGU members are tasked to help suppress and manage at the community level.

Livelihood. Refers to the alternative or additional means of income that CAFGU members pursue aside from their military service.

Militia. A civilian-based military group, such as CAFGU, organized to provide support to regular armed forces.

Paramilitary. A structured, armed group like CAFGU that functions similarly to the military but is composed mainly of trained civilian volunteers.

Real-life Situation. The actual experiences, challenges, and conditions of CAFGU members in their daily service and personal lives, as explored in this study.

CHAPTER II

METHODOLOGY

This chapter presents the research methodology, including the research design, research materials and methods, research environment, population and sample, research data and analysis plan and research ethical standards.

Research Design

For this study, a **phenomenological approach** will be used to explore real-life situation of CAFGU. This qualitative methodology is well-suited for capturing the complex dynamics and contextual intricacies of lived experiences. By focusing on individuals' personal narratives, phenomenology allows researchers to delve into the depth and breadth of human experiences, perceptions, and social phenomena (Neubauer BE, 2019). Through **face-to-face in-depth interviews**, this method will provide firsthand insights into the motivations, challenges, and real-life situations of CAFGU in P-10 Afga, Brgy. Lower Olave, **Buenavista, Agusan del Norte, Philippines**.

Qualitative research, particularly phenomenology, plays a crucial role in the social sciences by uncovering the complexity of human behavior and providing nuanced understandings that quantitative methods might overlook. This approach emphasizes the subjective meanings and personal interpretations individuals attach to their experiences, offering a rich, contextualized perspective on their realities. By employing phenomenology, this study aims to generate a deeper comprehension of the factors shaping male prostitution, ultimately contributing to a broader understanding of this social phenomenon (Lim, 2024).

The qualitative approach is a methodological approach that explores the intricacies of human experiences, perceptions, and social phenomena. It stands out for its dedication to comprehending the background, significance, and individualized interpretations people give to

their experiences. Qualitative research plays a crucial role in the social sciences by revealing the complexity and depth of human behavior and providing insights that quantitative methods might miss (Brinia, et al., 2020).

2.3 Research Environment

This study will be conducted within the boundaries of P-10 Afga, Brgy. Lower Olave, **Buenavista, Agusan del Norte, Philippines,** a first-class municipality located in the northeastern part of Mindanao. Buenavista, comprising **25 barangays**, is geographically positioned along the northern coast of Agusan del Norte and is recognized as one of the province's significant localities due to its agricultural resources and growing community development. Known for its strategic location and cultural diversity, the municipality plays a vital role in both local livelihood and security operations. According to the 2024 census, Buenavista has a population of **70,691,** which provides an essential backdrop for this study. With its distinct socio-cultural environment and proximity to security-sensitive areas, this municipality offers a relevant context for exploring the real-life situation of Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) members. Positioned within this setting, the study seeks to generate valuable insights into the roles, challenges, and contributions of CAFGU in strengthening the frontline operations of the Philippine Army.

Population and Sample

The population of the study consists of members of the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) currently residing in P-10 Afga, Brgy. Lower Olave,Buenavista, Agusan del Norte, Philippines. From this population, seventeen(17) participants were selected using purposive sampling. This sampling method was employed to ensure that only individuals with direct and relevant experiences could provide meaningful insights into the phenomenon under investigation.

The inclusion criteria required participants to be active CAFGU members who were willing to share their personal experiences. This enabled the researchers to gather rich and diverse perspectives regarding the socio-economic conditions, motivations, and challenges they encounter in their service. By engaging with respondents who possess firsthand knowledge of frontline operations, the study was able to capture nuanced accounts of their responsibilities, risks, and contributions to national security and community resilience.

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

The study will make use of qualitative data to be obtained from in-depth interviews with seventeen (17) purposively selected members of the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) in P-10 Afga, Brgy. Lower Olave,Buenavista, Agusan del Norte. The interviews will generate narrative accounts of the participants' socio-economic conditions, motivations, and challenges in relation to their service. Each interview will be audio-recorded, transcribed verbatim, and reviewed to ensure accuracy and completeness of responses.

The collected data will be organized, coded, and analyzed using thematic analysis. This process will involve identifying, categorizing, and interpreting recurring ideas and patterns from the participants' narratives. Emerging themes will be examined to capture both commonalities and differences in their lived experiences. The analysis will focus on the socio-economic realities, risks, and responsibilities faced by CAFGU members, with the goal of providing a nuanced understanding of their role in community security and national defense.

The findings will be presented in narrative form and supported by direct quotations from the participants to highlight authentic voices and perspectives. Tables and thematic maps will also be used to illustrate the organization of codes and themes that will emerge from the data.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

The researchers place a strong emphasis on incorporating ethical considerations throughout the entire research process when studying students in individual courses or within an entire program.

A. Protection of Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This research does not involve the creation of new technologies or products requiring patent protection. All materials to be used are original including self-developed survey questionnaires designed specifically for data gathering in this study, original research reports and written analyses prepared by the researcher throughout the course of the study, narrative discussions and interpretations which reflect original thought and synthesis, will be properly cited with permission where necessary. No unique brands, logos, or symbols requiring trademark protection are involved in this study.

B. Informed Consent

All seventeen (17) conversational partners are CAFGU members currently residing in P-10 Afga, Brgy. LowerOlave, Buenavista, Agusan del Norte, Philippines, who will be deliberately selected using **purposive sampling** will be informed about the purpose, procedures, risks, and benefits of the study through a brief orientation by the researchers. Written consent will be obtained from each participant. Ethical approval will also be secured from the appropriate institutional review board before starting the study. This study will not include animals as participants.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

Data will be collected through interviews, surveys, and focus group discussions, depending on the availability of participants and the type of information required. The chosen

methods aim to gather in-depth and reliable insights relevant to the objectives of the research. All data gathered will be anonymized to protect participants' identities. Personal identifiers will be removed or coded to ensure confidentiality. Access to the anonymized data will be strictly limited to authorized personnel directly involved in the study. Participants will be fully informed about the nature of data collection, storage, and potential sharing with third parties. When applicable, explicit consent will be obtained to ensure ethical compliance and transparency. Data management will follow standard ethical protocols to uphold participants' privacy and trust.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

Participation will be entirely voluntary for all human participants. Participants will be clearly informed of their right to withdraw at any time without facing any consequences. Ethical guidelines will be strictly followed with alternatives considered wherever possible. This study does not include animals as participants.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

Precautionary steps will be taken to minimize physical, psychological, and emotional harm to all human participants involved in the study. The following measures will be implemented such as obtaining informed consent, ensuring that participants understand the purpose of the research, their rights, and their freedom to withdraw at any time without any consequences, anonymity and confidentiality will be strictly maintained to protect participants' identities and personal information, non-invasive data collection methods such as surveys, interviews, and focus group discussions will be used to avoid any physical harm and providing support services, including access to counseling and referral to local mental health professionals, will be made available for participants experiencing distress during or after the study.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

The study aims to contribute positively to the academic field and society by addressing gaps in knowledge and highlighting the real-life situation of CAFGU members in the Philippines. For the academic community, it offers empirical data and insights that can enrich literature on community-based security forces, frontline military support, and socio-economic influences, while also serving as a reference for future research in related areas. For society, the study intends to inform policymakers, local government units, and the Philippine Army in designing targeted programs, enhancing support systems, and improving the welfare of CAFGU members. Results will be shared with participants and relevant stakeholders upon request to ensure transparency and mutual benefit.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

Participants will be selected using fair and transparent inclusion and exclusion criteria based on age, length of service, and willingness to voluntarily participate in the study. Inclusion criteria will focus on individuals who are active members of the Citizen Armed Force Geographical Unit (CAFGU) in P-10 Afga, Brgy. Lower Olave,Buenavista, Agusan del Norte, with direct experience in frontline duties and community security support. Exclusion criteria will omit those who are not active CAFGU members, have insufficient service experience, or are unable to provide informed consent. Efforts will be made to ensure diversity in terms of socioeconomic background, years of service, and personal experiences, while actively avoiding any form of discrimination. This study does not include animals as participants.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Standardized methods will be employed for accurate and reliable data collection and analysis. **This includes the use of validated interview guides, consistent procedures for conducting and recording interviews, and clear protocols for handling and storing data.** Data analysis will follow established qualitative research techniques, such as thematic analysis, to

ensure systematic interpretation and to enhance the verifiability of results. Despite these measures, the study acknowledges that certain limitations—such as participant availability, possible self-reporting bias, and contextual constraints—may arise. These will be transparently reported to provide a balanced and honest evaluation of the research outcomes.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

This study acknowledges the use of AI tools, including artificial intelligence-assisted writing and data organization platforms, to support the development of research materials, enhance clarity, and improve the overall quality of written outputs. These tools were used solely as aids and did not influence the integrity or objectivity of the research findings. There are no known conflicts of interest associated with this study. The researcher affirms that all findings will be reported truthfully and transparently, adhering to strict academic and ethical standards. Furthermore, all copyrighted materials utilized throughout the study will be properly cited and acknowledged in accordance with ethical research guidelines.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

No patented technologies will be used without proper clearance from the patent holders. Copyrighted materials, such as software and literature, will be utilized with appropriate permissions and citations. Proper acknowledgement of sources will be observed to ensure transparency.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

Human participants will be thoroughly informed about the purpose of the study, their roles, potential risks (such as emotional distress), and expected benefits. Informed consent will be obtained voluntarily, with assurances that participants could withdraw at any time without consequences. Strict confidentiality and anonymity protocols will be followed, and all data to be collected will be stored securely with restricted access to protect participant privacy.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Other Related Technologies

AI tools such as NVivo for qualitative data coding and ChatGPT for language refinement and thematic analysis support will be utilized to enhance the accuracy and Xefficiency of the research process. NVivo will assist in identifying patterns, coding transcripts, and organizing large volumes of qualitative data, while ChatGPT will support researchers in synthesizing literature and generating initial thematic insights. Steps will be taken to ensure that AI-driven processes do not compromise the integrity or authenticity of participant responses. All AI usage will be transparently disclosed in the methodology section before and after the study to maintain academic rigor and ethical accountability.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Ethical approval will be provided by the institutional review board of ethics committee of Saint Michael College of Caraga responsible for overseeing research involving human and animal subjects. The approval will be obtained before data collection began.

REFERENCES

Gana, M. L. (2022). *Joining militia: Drivers of militia participation in counter-insurgency in Yobe State, Nigeria* [PDF]. Mai Idris Alooma Polytechnic. https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Modu-Gana-2/publication/351169469_Joining_Militia_Understanding_the_Drivers_of_Militia_Participation_in_Coun terinsurgency_Operation_in_Yobe_State_Nigeria/links/60f48c1bfb568a7098bd1525/Joining-Militia Understanding-the-Drivers-of-Militia-Participation-in-Counterinsurgency-Operation-in-Yobe-State Nigeria.pdf

Mbukop, J. (2025). Youth Unemployment in Africa as a Catalyst of Conflicts and Insecurity: The Case of Cameroon. Available online at: https://dx.doi.org/10.47772/ IJRISS.2025.9020053 (Accessed March 11, 2025).

Carey SC, Mitchell NJ, Lowe W (2013) States, the security sector, and the monopoly of violence: A new database on pro-government militias. *Journal of Peace Research* 50 (2): 249–258.

Bagayaua, G. B. (2008). *Misuse of CAFGU funds still unresolved*. *Newsbreak*. Retrieved fromhttp://newsbreak.com.ph/index.php?option=com_content&task=view&id=5736&Itemid=888890666

Zech, S. T., & Eastin, J. (2019). The Household Economics of Counterinsurgency. *Defence and Peace Economics*, *32*(2), 220–239. https://doi.org/10.1080/10242694.2019.1688591

Eastin, J., & Zech, S. T. (2019). Joining the Counterinsurgency: Explaining Pro-Government Militia Participation in the Philippines. *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism*, *45*(9),817–841. https://doi.org/10.1080/1057610X.2019.1700029

• Carey, S. C., Colaresi, M. P., & Mitchell, N. J. (2016). *Risk mitigation, regime security, and militias: Beyond coup-proofing*. *International Studies Quarterly, 60*(1), 59-72. https://doi.org/10.1111/isqu.12210 Oxford Academic+1

• Clayton, G., & Thomson, A. (2016). *Civilianizing civil conflict: Civilian defense militias and the logic of violence in intra-state conflict*. *International Studies Quarterly, 60*(3), 499-510. https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqv011